



FREE RESOURCE · GUIDE 3 OF 5

Essay 2: Relationship Building and Influence

Turning a relationship into evidence: what Chevening rewards, common failure patterns, and how to write the influence essay well.

ABOUT THE EXAMPLES.

All names, institutions and statistics below are anonymised and reinvented versions of successful essays, changed to show technique. Yours must be real.

THE LIVE QUESTION.

Tell us about a professional relationship/network you have built and maintained in your workplace or in the community. In your answer, please address:

- How was the relationship formed, and what made it important?
- What did you contribute to this relationship, and what did you gain?
- How have you sustained or developed this relationship over time?
- How will these skills help you build connections within the Chevening community and beyond?

WORD LIMIT:

Minimum 100 / Maximum 300 words.

WHAT IS BEING SCORED.

Not sociability, and not the seniority of the people you know. Chevening wants evidence that you can build a working alliance with somebody whose cooperation you need and cannot compel, and that the alliance produced a real result.

STRUCTURE.

STARL (with Learning doing double duty for the Chevening paragraph).

WORD PLAN AT 300 WORDS

Situation 55 · Task 35 · Action 90 · Result 50 · Learning + Chevening 70

Part one: what this question actually tests

Three things must be in the essay:

1. A named counterpart with a title.
2. An exchange — what you brought and what you gained, both directions.

3. An outcome with a number or a named artefact attached.

The network test.

Does your draft prove that you build relationships that produce results, or only that you know people? If the second, rebuild around one relationship and one outcome.

Part two: naming in this essay

Name the counterpart with their position, the forum where you met, the broker if an introduction produced an outcome, and the joint output (by its actual name).

Rule: name and action in the same sentence. Four to eight proper nouns, every one attached to joint work.

Do not name beneficiaries, service users, patients or minors. Do not name anyone you could not discuss for two minutes at interview.

Part three: choosing the relationship

Pick one. Depth earns the mark.

Best category (if you have it): the relationship that began in disagreement or friction. It demonstrates influence rather than affinity.

Strong candidates: counterpart in another institution, someone who began as a critic, a community body with reason to distrust your employer, a mentor who became a collaborator, a peer whose method you needed.

Part four: writing it, beat by beat

S. How the relationship was formed and why it was important (~55 words)

Name the setting, name the person, and frame the gap as distance (why they were out of reach). Cross-boundary work counts double.

T. Shared goal (~35 words)

Name the specific, narrow technical aim you were both trying to achieve.

A. What you contributed, what you gained, and how you sustained it (~90 words)

State the exchange both ways.

Show the deliberate move you made to build the bridge.

Mark duration in years.

Show maintenance through joint output (not “we stayed in touch”).

Name the broker if relevant.

R. Result (~50 words)

What changed (number or named artefact) and what the relationship is now (present-tense sentence proving it is current).

L. Learning + Chevening (~70 words)

Name the transferable method.

Name a specific gap in the Chevening community you will help fill.

State what you will contribute back (not only what you will gain).

Part five: two full sample answers

All names, places and statistics are anonymised and reinvented. Do not copy.

Sample one — civil registration (298 words)

Registration reform in Katiba failed twice before I arrived because it was designed in the capital. The people who could make it work were midwives, and my employer, the Institute for Public Administration, had no standing with them at all. At a maternal health review in Sisan, Mrs Esther Bediako, president of the Katiba Midwives' Association, told me plainly that her members had been “consulted” three times and never told the outcome.

We set one aim: getting the birth notification slip issued at delivery rather than at the registrar's office, which is where families were being lost.

I brought the evidence and the route into government. I ran the three-province study that showed 71 per cent of unregistered children had been born with a skilled attendant present, and I took it to the Registrar General's office. Mrs Bediako brought legitimacy I did not have, convening four member consultations I could never have called. Over three years we have sustained it through joint work: co-drafting the notification protocol, training 34 midwives together, and presenting twice to the Civil Registration Technical Advisory Group. She introduced me to Dr Amina Sesay, the Registrar General, which is how the protocol reached national consideration.

The protocol was issued as national guidance in 2025, and 3,142 children have been registered through it in Katiba alone. Mrs Bediako now sits on the advisory group in her own right, which she does independently of me.

I learned that the sharpest critic of your programme is usually its most useful collaborator, because they have already done the analysis. Through Chevening I want to find alumni working on civil registration in comparable systems and propose a comparative study. I can offer a protocol that survived the full political process, including the parts that failed.

Sample two — school inspection (297 words)

The Katiba Inspectorate published school ratings that head teachers regarded as arbitrary, and compliance with our recommendations sat at 31 per cent. At a regional heads' meeting convened largely to complain about us, Mrs Doris Ankrah, head of Sisan Girls' Secondary, took the inspection framework apart clause by clause in front of forty colleagues. She was right about most of it. I asked whether she would help me rewrite it.

We set ourselves one objective: a framework head teachers could predict, measuring what a school can actually control.

I brought the data and the institutional route. I ran the analysis showing which of our eighteen indicators had no relationship with pupil outcomes, and I got the revision onto the Inspectorate's agenda. She brought legitimacy I did not have, convening three consultation sessions in schools that would not have opened their doors to me. Over three years we kept it going through joint work rather than goodwill: piloting the revised framework in eleven schools, co-presenting twice to the Ministry of Education, and running the annual induction for new inspectors together.

The revised framework was adopted regionally in 2025, compliance with inspection recommendations rose from 31 per cent to 68 in the first year, and four neighbouring regions have requested the induction materials. Mrs Ankrah now chairs the heads' panel that reviews the framework annually.

I learned to build around a shared technical problem rather than a title. In the Chevening community I want to find alumni working on school accountability, particularly in systems moving from compliance inspection toward improvement models, and propose a comparative study. I can contribute a framework that went through the full political process, including the two indicators we lost.

Part six: dos and don'ts

Do

- Choose one relationship and go deep
- Name the counterpart with position and the forum
- Frame the gap as distance
- State one narrow shared goal
- Give both sides of the exchange
- Show the deliberate move and mark duration in years
- Show maintenance through joint output
- Prove the relationship is current with a present-tense sentence
- Name a sector/gap and what you will contribute in the Chevening paragraph

Don't

- Describe networking philosophy
- List contacts or conferences

- Write only about what a mentor gave you
 - Name famous people or anyone you cannot discuss
 - Name beneficiaries or minors
 - End when the job ended
 - Write generic “I will engage with the diverse Chevening community”
 - Offer nothing back
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Part seven: checklist

While drafting

- ☐ One relationship, counterpart named with position
- ☐ Forum and why they were out of reach
- ☐ Narrow shared goal
- ☐ Contribution and gain both stated
- ☐ Deliberate move + duration in years
- ☐ Maintenance through joint outputs
- ☐ Number or named artefact at the result
- ☐ Present-tense sentence proving it is current

Before submitting

- ☐ All four live sub-questions visibly answered
- ☐ Four to eight proper nouns attached to joint work
- ☐ Chevening paragraph names a gap and what you offer
- ☐ Every figure real and every name spelled correctly
- ☐ At least one name recurs in Essay 1 or 4
- ☐ Within 100–300 words



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